

M T S Y A



m t s y a

मत्स्य

the first form, the keeper, the guide

B R A N D B O O K

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*There was a deluge.
A boat was carried through it,
tied to the horn of a fish,
and what the boat carried became the world.*

— the Mahabharata, retold

CHAPTER ONE

A small fish

Once, before the world was the world, a man named Manu was bathing in a river.

He cupped his hands to lift water to his face, and a fish — small, no longer than a fingernail — swam into them. It was alive in his palm. And then, impossibly, it was speaking.

Keep me. The big fish will eat the small fish. Keep me. The flood is coming.

Manu was the first man, the lawgiver, but he had never heard a fish speak. He kept it. He set it carefully into a clay pot, and walked home with the pot in his hands.

By morning the fish had outgrown the pot. He moved it to a larger vessel. By evening it had outgrown that one too. He carried it to a small tank in the courtyard. The fish grew. He carried it to a deeper lake at the village edge. The fish grew. He carried it to a tributary of the Ganges. The fish grew. In time he carried it to the great river itself, and walked home each evening half-believing that this would be enough.

It was not enough.

When the fish at last filled the Ganges and could not turn within it, Manu — by now afraid, by now suspecting — carried it to the ocean. There, in the

open salt water, the fish revealed itself. It was Vishnu, in his first form. It was Matsya.

A deluge is coming. Build a boat. Take with you the seven sages, every kind of seed, and the Vedas. When the rain begins, tie your boat to my horn. I will pull you through the water.

The rain began.

For days, then weeks, then a year, the rain did not stop. The mountains were swallowed. The forests were swallowed. The cities and the rivers and the names of things were swallowed. There was nothing but water, in every direction, beneath a sky that no longer existed.

But there was a boat. And the boat was tied to the horn of the fish. And the fish swam.

When the water at last fell, the boat came to rest on the one peak that remained — Himavant, in the high north of the dissolved world. Manu stepped onto wet rock. He carried with him, off the boat, what he had been told to carry: the seven sages, the seeds of every plant, the four Vedas. The world began again, from what had been kept.

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This is the first avatar of Vishnu. The first form. The fish who carried the world through the deluge.

CHAPTER TWO

The deluge

In the language we no longer speak fluently, the flood is called pralaya — dissolution.

It is not a punishment. It is not the anger of a god who has lost patience. It is, in the older reading, simply a turning of the wheel. The world ends. The world begins again. It has done so before. It will do so once more. Pralaya is what the universe does when it exhales.

And what the flood does, in the moment of its doing, is simple. It takes what is not essential and washes it away. It strips the surface from every surface. It returns the world to water — to the original element — and asks a single question of everything that floats by:

Should this be carried forward?

Most things, the answer is no. Most names, most cities, most habits, most clothes. The flood does not hate them. It is simply not their turn.

A few things, the answer is yes. The seeds. The knowledge. The people who can begin again. The boat that holds them, and the fish that knows the way.

Every man, eventually, asks his life this same question. Most pretend they are not asking it. The myth answers it for them, gently, in advance:

*Carry the seeds. Carry the knowledge. Carry the people. Build the boat
that holds these things, and tie it to something that knows the way.*

Everything else, you are allowed to lose.

CHAPTER THREE

What survives

A wardrobe is a small thing.

It is, in the end, fewer than a hundred objects. The working part of it — the part a man actually reaches for — is fewer than thirty. Of those, fewer than ten will see him through the year that matters. There is, somewhere in that drawer, a single shirt he packs first. He does not always know which one. But there is one.

Most clothing is not made to survive. Most clothing is designed to be replaced — by the next season, by the next slightly better version of the same idea, by the next image a man holds of himself. It lives in the foreground of his life and then it disappears. It was not asked to do anything more than that.

A few garments are different. They are not louder than the others. They are quieter. They are the ones a man returns to without thinking — the shirt he reaches for in the dark, the one in the bag at the start of every trip, the one that is somehow there in the photograph from the year his back started to hurt and the year he became a father and the year nothing went as he had planned.

These are the small, well-made, necessary things. The boat. The seeds. The book.

MTSYA makes those things.

It does not make collections. It does not make seasons. It does not make trends. It makes a small number of plain, beautifully cut, durably made

garments, in colours a man can live inside for years, in fabric that ages well, with details that are felt rather than seen. A capsule of objects designed for the floods that will come — the ones the calendar predicts, and the ones it does not.

This is not minimalism. Minimalism is a style; styles change. This is something older. This is preservation. This is what the fish carried in the boat.

CHAPTER FOUR

The name

The brand is called MTSYA. It is pronounced mat-syaa, the same as the Sanskrit word from which it descends — मत्स्य, matsya, fish.

The vowels are missing on purpose.

In the older Indian grammar, vowels are described as breath. Consonants are described as bone. A word is a body — a structure of bone, animated by breath. When a word is written without its vowels, only the structure remains. The breath has gone. What is left is what would be left after the deluge.

MTSYA is what survives of Matsya when the water falls.

It is the name of the moment after the rain, when the boat has come to rest, and the world is wet rock, and what is left is what was carried.

When you read the name aloud, you do something the brand quietly asks of you. You return the breath to the bone. You supply the missing vowels yourself, the way the rishis supplied the breath of the world by singing it. The reader is part of the structure. The wearer is part of the brand.

This is the brand's first idea, and it is announced before the customer has read a single word of copy. It is announced in the act of reading the name.

CHAPTER FIVE

The fish

There is a fish on the box, and on the inside-seam tag, and on the door of the studio, and at the closing of every letter the brand will ever write.



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The fish is drawn in the lineage of Madhubani painting — the Mithila tradition of Bihar where, for a thousand years, women have painted on the walls of their homes the great Indian myths in pattern, line, and devotion. The patterns on this fish are the same patterns that have appeared on the walls of mud houses in Madhubani villages for centuries. They are not decorative. They are how a story is held.

The fish is set in deep ink — the colour of writing, of inscription, of what is meant to last. It sits on cream paper. There is no other colour in the brand mark. The brand is two colours: ink and paper.

Everything else the brand makes will be plain.

This is intentional. The fish carries the cultural weight, so the wearer does not have to. The brand world is rich; the product is restrained. The box is luminous; the shirt is calm. The label is intricate; the shoulders are quiet. The man who wears MTSYA wears the calm. The richness is somewhere else — at home, on the shelf, on the door of the studio, in the founder's letter folded into the package.

This is the brand's signature, and it is the one rule we cannot break:

the brand carries the colour. the wearer carries the calm.

CHAPTER SIX

The wardrobe

MTSYA opens with five shirts and five T-shirts.

The shirts are made of Egyptian Giza cotton woven with TENCEL Lyocell — a fabric that is soft as silk, drapes like linen, and resists the wrinkle in the way that a well-told story resists being forgotten. They come in five colours, each named for a moment in the myth. They are not seasonal. They are not replaced. New colours arrive in time; the silhouettes do not change.

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Manu White

The first shirt. The boat. The foundational thing. It is plain, it is clean, it is what a man wears when he does not want to think about what he is wearing.

Deluge Indigo

The night shirt. The colour of water at the height of the flood. The dinner shirt, the late-evening shirt, the one a man wears when he wants the day to recede.

Veda Cream

The colour of old paper. The summer shirt. The reading shirt. The shirt for the long Sunday. The colour of what was preserved when everything else was washed away.

Tide Stone

A soft cool grey. The travel shirt. The one that goes in the bag first. The colour of the wet rock the boat finally rested on, when the water fell.

Coast Olive

The unexpected one. A muted, deep, forest-leaning green. The weekend shirt, the holiday shirt — the colour of life beginning again on dry land.

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Five colours. Three fits. One fabric. No prints. No logo on the chest. No seasonal collection. No marketplace listings, for at least the first eighteen months. The brand is allowed to be small. That is the whole idea.

CHAPTER SEVEN

The wearer

He is thirty-three.

He works at a venture-funded company in Bandra, or Indiranagar, or Hauz Khas Village. He earns enough that he no longer thinks about money the way he used to, but not enough that he has stopped thinking about it altogether. He travels twice a year for work, usually to Singapore or Dubai. He has a younger brother who calls him every Sunday.

He has, for some time now, been quietly tired.

Not of his life — his life is, on the whole, going well. He is tired of being sold to. He is tired of the brands that arrive in his feed every week with another version of the same idea, the same ten silhouettes, the same eight discount codes, the same urgent sense that the season is changing and he has fallen behind. He is tired of opening his wardrobe at seven in the morning and choosing between twelve shirts that all want something from him. He has not used these words, but he wants the choosing to stop. He wants a uniform.

He does not want a logo. He does not want to be told who he is. He does not want a story sold to him with a smile.

He wants — though he has not used these words either — a small set of objects he can stop thinking about.

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When he opens the MTSYA box for the first time, he reads the founder's letter. He learns the myth. He turns the shirt slowly in his hands. The fabric surprises him a little — softer than he expected; cooler than he expected. He puts the shirt on. It fits the way the photographs suggested it would, and also better than that.

Six months later, three of his ten most-worn shirts will be MTSYA. He will not have noticed when this became true.

He will not talk about the brand often. He will not post about it. But once, at dinner, a friend will ask him where the shirt is from, and he will pause for a moment — looking for the right way to explain — and then he will say:

'It's a small Indian brand. The name is from an old story. They make five shirts.'

That is all. That is enough.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The promise

The promise is a single line.

It is the line that will hang above the studio door. It is the line that will be embossed inside every box. It is the line that will sit on the back of every founder's letter — quietly, in the place where most brands print a logo and a tagline.

The wardrobe that endures the deluge.

This is what we make. This is what we have promised, in advance, to the man who has not yet found us. This is what the small fish, in the first form, in the first story we ever told ourselves about the world — set out to do.

To carry the small, necessary, well-made things through the change.

That is the brand. That is the work. That is all of it.

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